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What's next after social media's failure to its users?



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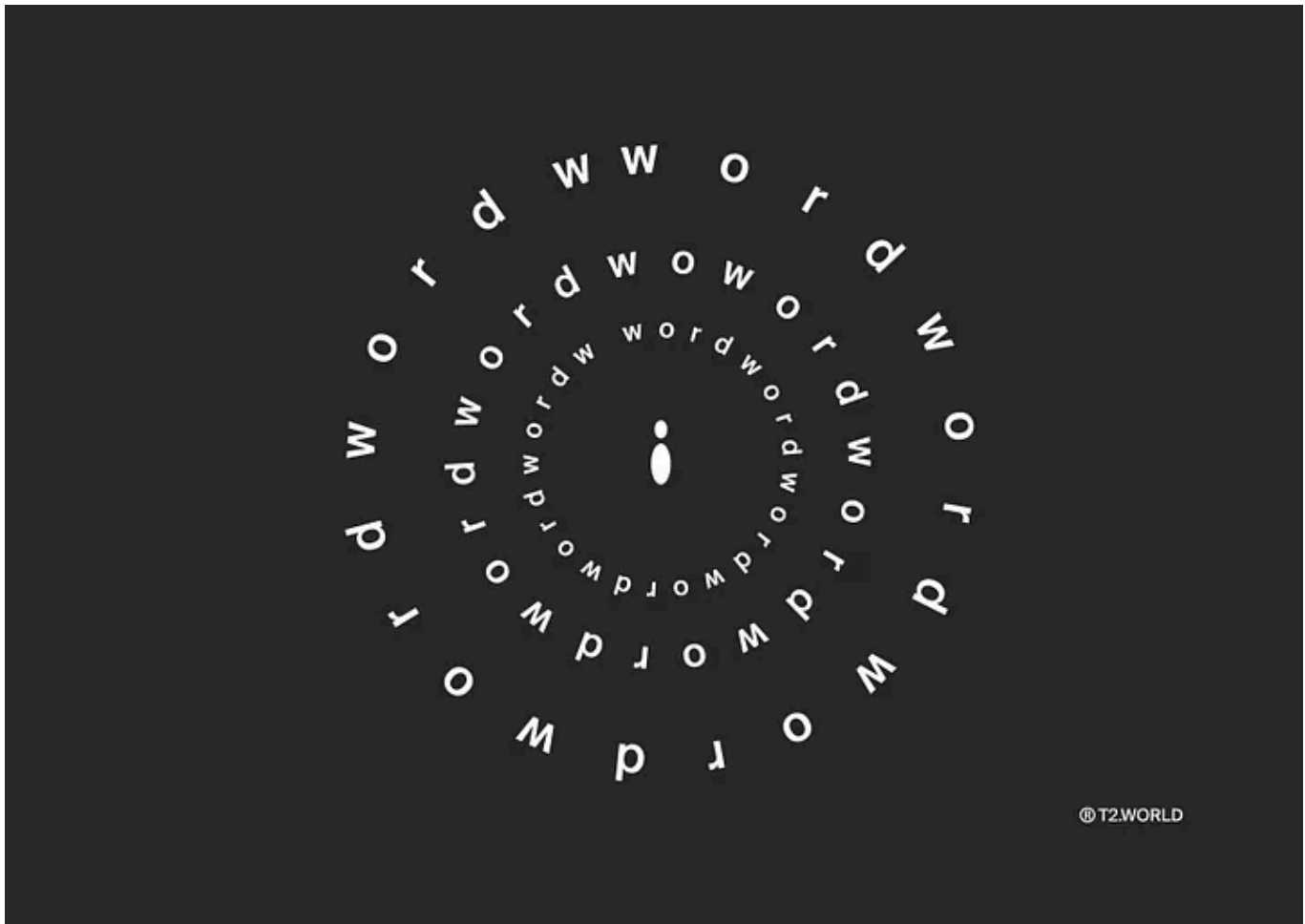
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With everything that's happening in the social media space right now — Elon Musk's purchase of Twitter and the subsequent layoffs that followed, Meta's mass layoffs and \$36 billion gamble on the metaverse that has yet to yield results, and the earlier collective negative reaction to Instagram's new algorithm — it's easy to say that the once darling of the internet has lost its luster, some might even say it's already dead, or at least on the way there.

But if we look at similar events in the social media timeline — from the rise and fall of Friendster, MySpace, Google+, Tumblr, Vine and many others that walked the same path — the space and all those in it are probably just changing. But what is it changing into? For Michael Mignano, it's transforming into what he calls the “recommendation media.”

We've come from 'social networks' to 'social media'

To talk about “recommendation media” is to acknowledge that social networks and social media came before it. And there’s a distinction between the two that will help explain how we got to this point in the timeline.

For Ian Bogost, a social network is an “idle, inactive system,” an interconnected web of static connections composed of users and their friends, their friends, and so on. This is what Facebook initially gave us. Over there we could find long-lost relatives, old colleagues, and classmates. It could grow and create more nodes, but it was essentially just a collection of users.

Social media, meanwhile, “is active — hyperactive really,” says Bogost. It cascades content — branded and user generated — through the aforementioned network of connected people. Social media is essentially a broadcast system that puts the power in the hands of those who create content and have the built-in audience at hand to spread it.

For Bogost, we saw traces of this when Instagram launched in 2010. “It relied on the connections among users as a mechanism to distribute content as a primary activity.” But as we’ve seen, this and other social networks eventually went the way of social media.

It’s all about relevant content

In recommendation media, the main mode of content distribution is no longer users’ network or social graph. Instead, content is shared through centralised algorithms.

These are designed to attract the most attention, bring forth the most emotion, and to produce the most engagement. The number of friends or

followers doesn't matter anymore. It's about serving the best and most compatible content to those who already enjoy it.

It's a battle of what's the best thing to watch, read, or listen to. And the winner gets all the views. TikTok is a prime example of this, and their content recommendation feature is perhaps the main reason why it's one of the few existing social media platforms that has seen impressive growth across users and engagement in the last few years.

On TikTok, one doesn't even need an account to start being fed by the algorithm. With zero accounts followed, anyone can begin watching and liking posts, and consequently, will be fed other related content. "To feed" is the appropriate verb because the only way to stop the buffet of content is to leave the table. And whatever is on the menu isn't always good for you.

Not all recommendations are good

What could go wrong with the recommendation media? A lot. When the decision on which content is shown to users is decided on by platforms and their algorithms — not by the user's social graph — it becomes a popularity contest of the best.

Sure, in the short term, they could push content creators to produce more well-made content. But eventually, it will all boil down to whichever gets people's attention the best.

And that usually involves using people's emotions to give them heightened versions of anger, humour, sadness, or inspiration. By then, it's not really about the truthfulness of the content within, but the emotions it can evoke to find itself in a user's recommendation feed and receive worthy views.

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For Mignano, the underlying data that powers social networks, the social graph, has become commoditized. So the thoughtfully created content we once consumed has become rare.

The answer lies in decentralised networks

One of the issues with contemporary social media according to Edward Ongweso Jr., who proclaimed that social media is dead, is that every major aspect of it is privately owned and run.

The data we generate, the servers that host it, their infrastructure, all these are not ours. So how much do these companies really care about us, their users?

“The solution isn’t to simply collectively choose another alternative, but to mobilize to undermine the current system, which, again, is hostile at every level to alternatives. And, until there’s a fundamental shift, we will never see true social media on a massive scale.” But that shift is happening right now with the growth of web3.

Using blockchain technology, platforms on Web3 eliminate the involvement of profit-driven third parties and their manipulative algorithms.

In the process, they open up opportunities for the users to participate in the growth, maintenance, and curation of the content on the platform.

Putting the 'media' back in 'social'

In our mission to promote deep reading, the content on the t2 platform is curated by our users — real people, not algorithms. And in the process, we are able to create even better content, curate deserving stories, deep read nourishing articles, and share our experiences to find each other in a space that promotes genuine connections. And the platform does this by recognizing users' passive contribution when reading.

For Charlie Warzel, the best argument that social media is on its way out is when algorithms start to fail at understanding what your users like. “Your platform will start to feel a bit like a mall where all the stores have been replaced by weird cellphone-case kiosks.” But if the users themselves curate the content based on what they pay attention to, then that can be addressed.

At t2, we believe that our attention is valuable, not only for ourselves, but also for its inherent superpower that can build and empower a collective better web.

Because if all users use their attention for good, not simply to just scroll through mindless content assumed to be relevant by algorithms, then social media will have a chance to be truly social, and truly filled with good media. It's time we shift from this 'attention economy' to the 'intention economy' where people and users have the power, not companies.

While others hope for social media to simply wither away, the best chance for it to fulfil the lofty promises its Web2 ancestors made is to make it human again, not machine-like.

“Social media was never a natural way to work, play, and socialize, though it did become second nature,” says Bogost. And part of being human is

recognising the people — the users — behind it and giving them a place and a responsibility in the creation and curation of the platform.

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Written by Peter Imbong, content creator at t2.

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About T2

At t2 (time²), we are building a transparent, decentralized, and collaborative social network around reading and writing. We capture the time you spend reading to cultivate better content, align incentives, and empower content-driven communities.

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